THE CATERPILLAR AND THE INFINITY STAIRCASE

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FADE IN:

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - DAWN

A sea of clouds. Out of it rises a staircase, climbing toward a distant glow. The camera pushes in on a tiny climber carrying a suitcase.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
There was once a caterpillar who was climbing a staircase.

EXT. MEADOW - FOOT OF THE STAIRS - MORNING MIST

Mossy, weathered first steps rise out of the grass. A cornerstone bears a worn, unreadable mark.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
Nobody knew who had built it.

Low angle. The stairs climb until they vanish into cloud.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
Nobody knew what was at the top.

EXT. PLAZA - FOOT OF THE STAIRS - NIGHT

A campfire. Young caterpillars sit in a circle around an ELDER with a white moustache.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
But the older caterpillars told stories.

The Elder rears up and spreads his arms. On the stair wall behind him, his firelit shadow becomes a butterfly.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
"Climb high enough," they said,

Among the listeners, OUR CATERPILLAR, young and green, fire in his eyes. He looks up at the stairs.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
"and you'll become a butterfly."

His awe settles into a small, determined smile. He blinks once.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - MORNING

Suitcase in hand, he hauls himself over the first step.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
So he climbed.

From straight above, the steps scroll beneath him like stripes.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
He climbed past thousands of steps.

He passes caterpillars slumped on the stairs. One lies flat. An empty suitcase lies open beside them.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
Past caterpillars who had given up.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - HARD AFTERNOON

A bone-white skeleton reaches for the next step, its dusty suitcase beside it. His shadow crosses it as he passes.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
Past the skeletons of those who had died trying.

He stops at a wall covered in carvings: words, tally marks, a butterfly doodle.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
Some had left messages carved into the walls.

Raking light across the stone: KEEP GOING.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
(whispering)
Keep going.

THE TOP IS WORTH IT.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
The top is worth it.

YOU'RE ALMOST THERE. Beneath the words, a skeleton.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
You're almost there.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - AFTERNOON

A plum-coloured caterpillar, the DESCENDER, crawls down head-first toward him. They stop face to face.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
One day, he came across a caterpillar descending the staircase.

Our caterpillar, eager.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
"What's at the top?" he asked.

The Descender lifts an arm toward the sky. Warm light falls from above.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
"Glory," the caterpillar replied.

Our caterpillar, hopeful.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
"Have you seen it?"

The Descender's eyes slide away.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
"No."

He shrugs and carries on down.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
"But I've heard."

Our caterpillar watches him go.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - TIME-LAPSE

Day and night roll over. Clouds stream past. He inches upward.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
Years passed.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - OVERCAST

He is older now: paler, antennae drooping, heavy-lidded, sweating.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
His body grew tired.

His little feet tremble and slip on the edge of a step.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
His legs weakened.

He exhales. His whole body deflates.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
(a sigh)
But he kept climbing

He heaves himself onto the next step. He peers over the edge, and the staircase stretches away behind him, impossibly far.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
because the thought of remaining a caterpillar terrified him more than the staircase.

He turns back to the stairs, sets his jaw, and climbs into the wind.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - RED DUSK

He tries a step and slides back.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
One day, he couldn't take it anymore.

He rears up and screams.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
He stopped climbing and screamed at the top of his lungs.

Extreme wide. He is a speck on the endless stairs.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - NIGHT

The camera tilts up the stairs into the clouds. The clouds begin to glow.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
Then, from somewhere above, a voice called out.

Warm light pulses over his face with every phrase. Hope returns.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
"You're almost there. Don't give up now. You've come so far!"

The light ebbs. His smile fades. Something to the side catches his eye.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
But something was different this time.

Climber after climber along the stairs, each lit by the same light, each looking up with the same face.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
For the first time, he noticed that every caterpillar was hearing the same voice.

A huge pull-back: hundreds of climbers dotted along an endless staircase, all lit by the same pulse.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
And every single one of them was almost there.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - PRE-DAWN

His view up the stairs, into forever.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
He looked up at the endless staircase.

The worn suitcase in his hand. A little butterfly luggage tag.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
Then he looked at his little suitcase.

For the first time, the camera is still. He sets the suitcase down and settles onto the step.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
And finally, he sat down.

Clouds drift. The sun comes up.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
For a while, he waited.

He glances up, then around.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
He wasn't sure what he expected to happen.

A blink.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
But nothing did.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - MORNING

The staircase. Clouds roll by.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
The staircase carried on as it always had.

Climbers crawl past him without looking.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
The other caterpillars did too.

He looks down at himself. Still a caterpillar.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
And he was still just as he was before.

A sunbeam breaks through and lands on him. Then a cloud slides over it.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
There was no revelation or enlightenment.

He glances over his shoulder. A dotted outline of wings flickers on his back: missing.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
There were no wings.

The top: just clouds, as distant as ever.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
And certainly, there was no glory.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - GOLDEN HOUR

His face softens into a small, real smile.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
But for the first time in his life, he wasn't miserable.

He turns from the stairs to the view, slowly. The camera pulls back, settling on the sunset over the sea of clouds.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
For the first time, he was just there.

His silhouette and his suitcase against the setting sun.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
And that was enough.

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - DUSK

The sun has set. He turns his head back up the stairs.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
He looked up at the staircase once more.

His eyes, up close.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
And for the first time, he wondered...

EXT. THE STAIRCASE - NIGHT

A long crane up the staircase, through the clouds and into the stars, past tiny climbers. The stairs never end.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
What if the top was invented by caterpillars who couldn't bear the thought that climbing was all there was?

The camera eases to a stop on the stairs climbing into the stars.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END